

文 法 Grammar

1 Comparison between Two Items

In Japanese, adjectives do not change form in comparative sentences; there is no alteration as in “great/greater.” You can express the idea of comparison by framing a sentence like:

A のほうが B より¹ (property)。 = A is more (property) than B.

中国のほうが日本より大きいです。
ちゅうごく にほん おお

China is larger than Japan.

If you want to ask a question comparing two items, you can say:

A と B と どちらのほう / どちらのほう² が (property)。
= Between A and B, which is more (property)?

So a typical exchange looks like this:

A : 日本とカナダとどちらのほうが寒いですか。
にほん さむ

Which is colder, Japan or Canada?

B : カナダのほうが寒いです。
さむ

Canada is colder.

2 Comparison among Three or More Items

In comparison among three or more items, the degree qualifier いちばん is used.

{ A と B と C } の中で A がいちばん (property)。
なか
= A is the most (property) [among (the group of items)].

¹ In real life, the phrases Aのほうが and Bより often appear in the reverse order, making it very easy to be misled into believing the opposite of what is actually said. Don't rely on the word order, therefore, to decide which item is claimed to be superior. Listen carefully for the words のほうが and より.

² In place of どちらのほう and どちらのほう, you can also use どちら and どちら. Any one of these can be used in question sentences seeking comparisons between two items. どちら and どちらのほう are slightly more colloquial than どちら and どちらのほう.

A : カナダとフランスと日本の中で、どこがいちばん寒いですか。

Among Canada, France, and Japan, which country has the coldest climate?

B : カナダがいちばん寒いと思います。

Canada is the coldest, I think.

A : 季節の中でいつがいちばん好きですか。

What season do you like best?

B : 秋がいちばん好きです。

I like fall the most.

Note that the words *のほう* and *どちら* are not used in statements of comparison among three or more items. Normal question words like *だれ*, *どれ*, *何*, *いつ*, and *どこ* are used instead.³

3 Adjective/Noun + の

When a noun follows an adjective, and when it is clear what you are referring to, you can replace the noun with the indefinite noun *の*, “one,” to avoid repetition. *の* mostly stands for things, not people.⁴

私は黒いセーターを持っています。赤いのも持っています。(の=セーター)

I have a black sweater. I have a red one, too.

ケーキがたくさんあります。好きなのを持っていってください。(の=ケーキ)

We have a lot of cakes. Take the ones you like.

い-adjective な-adjective	} + noun	→	い-adjective な-adjective	} + の
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³ The tendency is to use *どれ* when a list of items is presented, and to use *何* when a group is referred to collectively. Compare:

りんごとみかんとさくらんぼの中で、どれがいちばん好きですか。

Which do you like best, apples, tangerines, or cherries?

くだものの中で、何がいちばん好きですか。

What fruit do you like best?

⁴ When you want to refer indefinitely to people, use *人* instead of *の*, as in *頭がいい人* “smart people.” The use of *の* to indicate people is largely limited to sentences like *あそこで歌っているのは田中さんです* (The one who is singing over there is Tanaka.), where you describe a person with *～の* is first, and then name that person with *～です*.

You can also use の in the sense of “mine,” “yours,” and so forth, referring to things owned by a person, or characterized by a place name, for example.

A: これはソラさんのかばんですか。 *Is this Sora's bag?*

B: いいえ、それはメアリーさんのかばんです。 *No, that is Mary's.*

アメリカの車のほうが日本の車より大きいです。
くるま にほん くるま おお
American cars are larger than Japanese ones.

noun₁ の noun₂ → noun₁ の noun₂

4 ～つもりだ

つもり follows verbs in the present tense short forms to describe what a person is planning to do in the future. You can also use a verb in the negative plus つもり to describe what you are planning *not* to do, or what you do *not* intend to do.

verb (short, present) + つもりだ (I) intend to do ...

(私は)週末にたけしさんとテニスをするつもりです。
わたし しゅうまつ

I intend to play tennis with Takeshi this weekend.

山下先生はあした大学に来ないつもりです。
やましたせんせい だいがく こ

Professor Yamashita does not intend to come to school tomorrow.

You can also use the past tense to talk about your original intention, which did not materialize.

お寺を見に行くつもりでしたが、天気がよくなかったから、行きませんでした。
でら み い てん き

We were planning to visit a temple, but we didn't, because the weather was not good.

5 Adjective + なる

The verb なる means “to become,” indicating a change. なる follows nouns and both types of adjectives.

い-adjectives:	暖かい	→	暖くなる	<i>to become warm/warmer</i>
な-adjectives:	静か(な)	→	静かになる	<i>to become quiet/quieter</i>
nouns:	会社員	→	会社員になる	<i>to become a company employee</i>

日本語の勉強が楽しくなりました。

Studying the Japanese language is fun now (though it was like torture before).

日本語の勉強が好きになりました。

I have grown fond of studying the Japanese language.

With い-adjectives, the final い is dropped and く is added, just like in their negative conjugations. A common mistake is to use the な-adjectives pattern になる for い-adjectives and say, for example, ×暖かいになる。
あたた

When you use an adjective with なる, you may be describing an absolute change (e.g., “it has become warm, hence it is not cold any longer”) or a relative change (e.g., “it has become warmer, but it is still cold”). If you want to make clear that you are talking in relative terms, you can use the pattern for comparison together with なる.

メアリーさんは前より日本語が上手になりました。

Mary has become better in Japanese than before.

6 どこかに / どこにも

In Lesson 8 we learned the Japanese expressions for “something” and “not . . . anything,” 何か and 何も. As you must have noticed, these expressions are made up of the question word for things, 何, plus particles か and も. Other expressions for “some” and “any” in Japanese follow this pattern. Thus,

something	何か <u> </u>	someone	だれか <u> </u>	somewhere	どこか <u> </u>
not anything	何 <u> </u> も	not anyone	だれ <u> </u> も	not anywhere	どこ <u> </u> も

As we noted in Lesson 8, you do not need the particles は, が, or を with these words. You do need other particles, such as に, へ, and で. These particles appear in the places shown with underlines above.

A : どこか へ 行きましたか。

Did you go anywhere?

B : いいえ、どこ へ も 行きませんでした。

No, I didn't go anywhere.

A : だれか に 会いましたか。

Did you see anybody?

B : いいえ、だれ に も 会いませんでした。

No, I didn't see anybody.

A : 何か に しましたか。

Did you do anything?

B : いいえ、何 に も しませんでした。

No, I didn't do anything.

(を is not used.)

7 で

You can use the particle で with nouns that describe the means of transportation and the instruments you use.

はしでご飯を食べます。
はん た

We eat our meals with chopsticks.

日本語で話しましょう。
にほんご はな

Let's talk in Japanese.

バスで駅まで行きました。
えき い

I went to the station by bus.

テレビで映画を見ました。
えい が み

I saw a movie on TV.

Expression Notes

10

表現ノート

ひょう げん

買ってきます ▶ In the dialogue, Mary tells Takeshi that she will get a souvenir for him during her trip to Hokkaido. You can use a verb *te*-form (買って in this example) + くる to describe an action performed somewhere else, followed by a movement to your current location.

バスツアーがありますが…… ▶ We sometimes use が and けど (but) at the end of a sentence when we want our partners to treat what we have just said as a given, common ground to build upon. These words often indicate the speaker's intention to give her partner a chance to react and speak up. By relegating the right to speak to one's partner, they also contribute to the politeness of one's utterance.

In the dialogue, the hotel employee lays out the relevant information on the table; there are two tours, one on Saturday and another on Sunday. が attached to her sentence indicates that she wants to build upon, and move forward with, these pieces of information. Instead of asking the obvious question, namely, どちらがいいですか, the hotel employee chooses not to finish her sentence, and lets her customer come forward with an answer immediately.